



WORLD FOOD PROGRAMME (WFP)

Background Paper

Topic: Addressing Extreme Food Insecurity and Famine in Conflict-Affected Regions

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I. The World Food Programme (WFP): History and Powers

The World Food Programme (WFP) is the food assistance branch of the United Nations and the world's largest humanitarian organization addressing hunger and food security. It was established in 1961 by the UN General Assembly and the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO).

Historical Background

WFP was created to provide emergency food aid and combat global hunger. Over time, its mandate expanded to include long-term food security, nutrition programs, and resilience-building initiatives in vulnerable communities.

WFP operates in more than 120 countries and territories, delivering assistance to millions of people affected by conflict, natural disasters, and economic crises. In 2020, WFP was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize for its efforts in combating hunger and contributing to peace in conflict-affected areas.

WFP has played a central role in:

- Emergency food distribution
- School feeding programs
- Nutrition support for mothers and children
- Logistics coordination in humanitarian emergencies
- Strengthening food systems in fragile states

Powers and Functions

WFP has the authority to:

- Deliver emergency food and cash-based assistance
- Coordinate large-scale humanitarian logistics operations
- Conduct food security assessments
- Support governments in developing national food security strategies
- Collaborate with other UN agencies and NGOs

Although WFP does not pass binding resolutions, its operational capacity and policy recommendations significantly influence global food security strategies.

II. Introduction to the Topic

Extreme food insecurity and famine are among the most urgent humanitarian crises facing the international community. Conflict remains one of the primary drivers of hunger, disrupting food production, supply chains, markets, and livelihoods.

In conflict-affected regions, civilians often face displacement, destruction of agricultural infrastructure, and limited humanitarian access, increasing the risk of famine and widespread malnutrition.

III. Historical and Structural Background

Historically, famine has been closely linked to armed conflict. War destroys farmland, interrupts trade routes, damages water systems, and forces communities to flee their homes.

Key factors contributing to extreme food insecurity in conflict zones include:

- Destruction of crops and livestock
- Blockades and restricted humanitarian access
- Economic collapse and inflation
- Climate-related shocks combined with instability
- Targeting of food systems and infrastructure

Regions frequently affected include parts of Sub-Saharan Africa, the Middle East, and areas experiencing prolonged instability.

Food insecurity often worsens when conflict overlaps with droughts, floods, or economic crises, creating compound humanitarian emergencies.

IV. Humanitarian and Socio-Economic Impacts

Extreme food insecurity in conflict zones has severe consequences:

1. Malnutrition and Mortality

Acute malnutrition, especially among children under five, significantly increases mortality rates.

2. Displacement

Food shortages force families to migrate internally or across borders.

3. Economic Collapse

Agricultural disruption undermines livelihoods and local markets.

4. Social Instability

Competition over scarce resources may intensify violence and prolong conflict.

5. Intergenerational Consequences

Chronic malnutrition affects cognitive development, education outcomes, and long-term economic productivity.

These impacts disproportionately affect women, children, and marginalized communities.

V. International Framework

Relevant international frameworks include:

- The Rome Declaration on World Food Security
- The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially:
 - SDG 2: Zero Hunger
 - SDG 1: No Poverty
 - SDG 16: Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions
- International Humanitarian Law protecting civilian access to food
- UN Security Council resolutions addressing conflict-induced hunger

Despite global commitments, funding gaps and access restrictions continue to hinder famine prevention efforts.

VI. Current Situation (2026 Context)

As of 2026:

- Millions of people remain at risk of famine in conflict-affected regions.

- Humanitarian access remains restricted in several active conflict zones.
- Global food prices remain volatile due to geopolitical tensions and climate disruptions.
- Funding shortages limit the scale of emergency operations.
- Climate change increasingly compounds conflict-driven food insecurity.

The international community faces urgent pressure to prevent famine before it becomes widespread and irreversible.

VII. Key Questions for Debate

Delegates should consider:

- How can WFP secure humanitarian access in active conflict zones?
- What mechanisms can prevent famine before it reaches catastrophic levels?
- Should international funding for food assistance be increased or restructured?
- How can local agricultural systems be strengthened during and after conflict?
- What role can cash-based assistance and innovation play in improving food security?

VIII. Conclusion

Extreme food insecurity and famine in conflict-affected regions represent a direct threat to global stability and human survival.

The World Food Programme plays a vital role in:

- Delivering life-saving food assistance
- Coordinating humanitarian logistics
- Supporting long-term resilience and recovery
- Preventing hunger from escalating into famine

Delegates must develop comprehensive strategies that address both immediate emergency needs and long-term structural causes of hunger to ensure sustainable peace and food security worldwide.